

Starting Your Dream Project

A short, step-by-step guide for young founders who want land, community, and meaningful work — and don't yet know in what order to do it.

Why this guide exists

Most young people with a vision for an eco-project, intentional community, or land-based school make the same mistake: **they look for land first**. Land is emotional, visible, and feels like progress. But almost every successful community of the last sixty years did it in a different order. They found **people** first, built a **form** second, and only then bought **land**.

This guide walks through that order, as a sequence you can actually follow. Read it once, then we can talk through it together.

The core reframe

You don't have €20,000. You have a seed. Alone, it buys nothing useful. Pooled with seven other committed people, it becomes €160,000 — which in interior Portugal, Spain, or southern Italy can buy a small farm with buildings.

So the real question is not *where is my land* but:

Who are my seven people, and what vessel will hold us together when things get hard?

The seven steps, in order

Step 1. Write the vision down

One page. Spend a week on it.

State what you are building, what you are NOT building, and what level of commitment is required. Be specific enough to exclude people. A vague manifesto attracts everyone and commits no one; a specific one attracts three people — and those three are the project.

Success looks like: you can read the page aloud without flinching. Someone who isn't aligned would finish it and say "not for me" — and that's the right outcome.

Step 2. Put yourself in front of aligned people, BEFORE asking anyone to join

Ongoing — months, not weeks.

Teach a short course. Write publicly. Host an event. Run a weekend. Every founder of a successful community already had a public practice that drew in the people who eventually became co-founders. They didn't invent an audience — they converted one.

Success looks like: a handful of people are showing up to your things repeatedly, asking good questions, and writing back.

Step 3. Send a narrow call

Once you have a small audience.

Not *"who wants to live on a farm?"* — but *"here is the vision, here is the commitment, come to a weekend and let's see if we fit."* The weekend is the filter. Expect most people not to come back. That is the system working.

Success looks like: 10-20 people attend a modest weekend, and 3-5 of them ask when the next one is.

Step 4. Live together temporarily — before buying land

A season, ideally a year.

A rented house, a seasonal work camp, a co-housing arrangement. This is where most groups die, and it is supposed to be. You are finding out whether you can cook, clean, fight, and decide together. Skipping this phase is the single most reliable way to blow up after buying land.

Success looks like: the group survives a real disagreement and is still eating dinner together.

Step 5. Choose a legal form BEFORE buying land

Boring. Essential.

In Portugal this is usually an *associação*, a *cooperativa*, or in some cases a *fundação*. The form separates the project from any one person, protects the project if someone leaves, and makes fundraising possible. This is the most important decision you will make. Do not skip it or defer it because "we'll figure it out later."

Success looks like: a registered legal entity with a bank account and an agreement the core group has signed.

Step 6. The legal entity buys the land — not a person

Now, and only now.

Marginal rural land in interior Portugal still trades at €1,500-5,000 per hectare. Old stone ruins and abandoned quintas come up regularly. A group of eight with pooled capital and a legal vehicle is a serious buyer. An individual with €20k is not.

Success looks like: you sign the deed as the legal entity, not as yourself.

Step 7. A public offering funds the next phase

Years 1-5 after land purchase.

Courses, residencies, work-stays, markets, events. Projects that skipped this — pure homesteading, no public face — almost always ran out of money in the first three years. The public offering is also how you keep attracting the next wave of aligned people.

Success looks like: the project earns enough to cover its basic operating costs without any one person subsidising it.

A practical first year, month by month

If you're starting from zero right now, this is roughly what the first 24 months look like.

Months 1-3 — Write and publish. Write your one-page manifesto. Share it in three places: your personal network, an international community like ic.org or GEN Europe, and one in-person event where aligned people already gather.

Months 3-6 — First weekend. Run a cheap, modest weekend. Ten to twenty people. A friend's land, a rented finca, a borrowed space. The goal isn't to start the community — it is to see who comes back.

Months 6-12 — Returners and co-writing. Quarterly gatherings with the people who returned. Co-write the vision. Identify four to eight potential co-founders. Decide on the legal form.

Months 12-18 — Shared rental. A house or finca the core group lives in or uses intensively together. This is the real filter.

Months 18-24 — Legal entity, land search, first course. Set up the associação or cooperativa. Pool money. Search for land as a group. Run a public course from the rental base to test the

economic engine before committing to a purchase.

Your €20,000 is the seed for the rental phase and the legal setup. It is NOT the seed for buying land.

Questions to bring to our conversation

- What is the one sentence that describes your project — specifically enough that it would turn some people away?
- Where are you already in front of aligned people? If nowhere yet, that is step zero.
- Who are the three people you would invite to a first weekend in the next ninety days?
- What is the smallest public offering — a course, a weekend, a residency — that you could run in the next six months from any space, even rented?
- What are you afraid of losing by being specific?